

Chastity's LaTeX Book

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This short example book was written in LaTeX by Chastity to remind herself why she was learning LaTeX. It was converted to PDF by the pdflatex program running on Debian Linux.

Chapter 1

What is LaTeX?

LaTeX is a language for describing documents that you might want to print or just view on a computer. It is similar to what HTML is for web pages because you have tags representing different kinds of elements. Many people say it is extremely helpful for making scientific papers or books representing math formulas that are hard to represent using traditional word processors or Markdown.

Because it is a plain text format, it can be edited using any text editor and doesn't require using special software. In particular, it avoids the need for Microsoft Word that many people are told to use. LibreOffice is a good GUI alternative to Microsoft Word but sometimes plain text is the fastest, especially for editing a document using a terminal only environment on a Linux that may not even have the X Window System installed.

Chapter 2

Why am I Learning LaTeX?

My own interest in LaTeX began when Matthew Moodie was editing my DOS edition of Assembly Arithmetic Algorithms. He told me he was using LaTeX in combination with Markdown and converting with Pandoc. I have written many books using Markdown and my files usually make great ebooks but when it comes to paperback books, my knowledge and skill is more limited and I rely on LibreOffice or Leanpub for converting my books into readable PDF files.

By using other people or software, I am trusting them to make the decisions on things like paper size or font size. However, this is not good enough for an autistic person like me who wants to control everything about my computer usage, including the programs I write and books I write about those programs!

By learning more about LaTeX, I hope to fill this gap in my knowledge so that I can use it to write a future book using it and not rely on other people or GUI tools that I don't understand well. Plain text has always been my style of getting work done on the computer. LaTeX is just as capable as Markdown but perhaps more expressive in formatting.

Chapter 3

Goals of this LaTeX Book

The books I usually write are very simple. At least, a book contains text separated into chapters and sections within chapters. Sometimes this text is bold or italic, and sometimes, the text is meant to be separated into a code block showing the source code of a program.

More complex books require the use of images, such as my book: Chastity's Chess Chapters. Images are the best way to render anything where the look must be perfect, but they also take time to create and are tricky to include in books because GUI editors like to choose where they appear and force the user to click and drag with a mouse to reposition them or right click and open a dialog box to resize them.

The headache I just mentioned about images is one I experienced and ultimately what forced me to learn Markdown. The goals of this book are to learn how to use LaTeX to do everything I could have done with Markdown and perhaps more as I learn the capabilities of LaTeX and how I can use it to make books on Arithmetic and Computer Programming Languages.